Card Master, Revised

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An elven woman sits opposite a stuffed-shirt noble, waving her hands over a crystal ball as she plucks cards from the deck in front of her. She whispers tales of woe and misfortune, a terrible fate that will surely occur unless the noble pays the penalty. Sobbing, the noble tears off his gold and jewels, casting them to the ground. The elf smiles, knowing that no matter what cards she had drawn, the result would be to her benefit.

A human, cloaked in brown and black, is cornered in an alleyway. He holds out a hand, revealing that he is unarmed, save for his trusty deck of cards. There is a flash of light and an explosion of color, and in the dust left behind, the man picks up his discarded cards, leaving one behind — the Ace of Spades, his favorite calling card.

Two men dressed in ornate clothing stand on opposite sides of an arena, amid the sounds of cheering spectators. They channel their magics into their decks, ready to pit them against each other in a ritualistic battle for glory, fame... and perhaps blood.

A Different Kind of Magic

A card master is a practitioner of a mystical art that relies on cards as a magical implement. Instead of flimsy wands, clumsy staves, or messy spell components, card masters focus their magical power into their collection of arcane cards, releasing the stored energy in the form of fiery explosions, flashing illusions, and crackling lightning, among other spectacles.

Their magic is seen as unorthodox and childish by their peers, who do not understand the intricacies of card magic. Because of this stigma, or perhaps in spite of it, a card master's talents for manipulating magic as well as the people around them is always in demand. Some card masters use their gifts in nomadic solitude, stealing from the unsuspecting or drifting from tavern to tavern to gamble or offering their services as a mercenary. Others flaunt their power in public, seeking out others of their ilk to either collaborate and trade with or to battle for superiority.

In combat, a card master's talents are suited to supporting their allies and weakening their enemies through strategic use of their cards. However, in a pinch, a good card master always has an ace up their sleeve, able to unleash a powerful spell to keep an enemy at bay, giving their allies time to regroup... or, perhaps, for the card master themselves to make a clean getaway.

Creating a Card Master

Every card master begins with a small starter set of cards. How did your character obtain this set of cards? Did you have a master you learned from? Did you find them in a ancient ruin, and then experiment with them until you figured out how to use them? Did you have natural talent, or did it come slowly to you after years of practice?

What causes you to start adventuring? Are you on a quest to add to your collection? Have you taken on an apprentice to whom you are teaching your art? Or perhaps you simply wish to put your newfound power to the test.

Class Features

A card master gains the following class features:

Hit Points

Hit Dice: 1d8 per card master level
Hit Points at 1st Level: 8 + your Constitution modifier
Hit Points at Higher Levels: 1d8 (or 5) + your Constitution modifier per card master level after 1st

Proficiencies

Armor: Light armor
Weapons: Simple weapons, sidearms and firearms with the *scatter* property
Tools: Gaming set (playing cards)

Saving Throws: Intelligence, Charisma
Skills: Choose two from Acrobatics, Arcana, Deception, Insight, Intimidation, Investigation, and Sleight of Hand

Quick Build

You can make a card master quickly by following these suggestions. First, Charisma should be your highest ability score, followed by Dexterity or Constitution. Second, choose the Charlatan background. Third, choose *card throw*, *minor illusion*, and *light* as your cantrips, and add the following spell cards to your collection: *burning hands, color spray, disguise self,* and *shield*.

Equipment

You start with the following equipment, in addition to the equipment granted by your background:

- *(a)* a light crossbow and 20 bolts or *(b)* any simple weapon or *(c)* a primitive firearm and 20 rounds
- *(a)* a scholar's pack or *(b)* a dungeoneer's pack
- leather armor, a playing card set, and two daggers



The Card Master

Level	Proficiency Bonus	Features	Cantrips Known	Deck Points	Maximum Spell Level
1st	+2	Card Magic, Full House	3	4	1st
2nd	+2	Following Suit	3	6	1st
3rd	+2	Cycling	3	14	2nd
4th	+2	Ability Score Improvement	4	17	2nd
5th	+3	—	4	27	3rd
6th	+3	Suit Feature	4	32	3rd
7th	+3	Awe Strike	4	38	4th
8th	+3	Ability Score Improvement	4	44	4th
9th	+4	—	4	57	5th
10th	+4	Suit Feature	5	64	5th
11th	+4	Legendary Card (6th level)	5	75	5th
12th	+4	Ability Score Improvement	5	75	5th
13th	+5	Legendary Card (7th level)	5	85	5th
14th	+5	Suit Feature	5	85	5th
15th	+5	Legendary Card (8th level)	5	95	5th
16th	+5	Ability Score Improvement	5	95	5th
17th	+6	Legendary Card (9th level)	5	100	5th
18th	+6	—	5	100	5th
19th	+6	Ability Score Improvement	5	100	5th
20th	+6	Deck of Legends	5	125	5th

Card Magic

Your magic comes from your cards, specially scribed pieces of stiff wood sheets, vellum, or another laminated material, bearing the arcane glyphs required to focus and unleash magical energy.

Cantrips

At 1st level, you know the cantrip *card throw* as well as two other cantrips from the card master spell list. You learn additional card master cantrips of your choice at higher levels, as shown in the Cantrips Known column of the Card Master table.

Your Growing Card Collection

At 1st level, you have a collection of four 1st-level card master spell cards of your choice. Additionally, each time you gain a card master level, you can add two additional card master spell cards of your choice to your collection. Each of these spell cards must be a spell from the card master spell list whose level is no higher than your Maximum Spell Level, as shown in the column in the Card Master table.

You may also come across other spell cards over the course of your travels, either by themselves as one would find a spell scroll, or perhaps by finding another card master who is willing to share their gains with you. It is assumed that card masters have multiple copies of their spell cards that they are willing to trade, so no spells are lost as a result of these trades.

Finally, if you find a spell written in a scroll or spell book, if the spell is on the card master spell list, you can create a new spell card for that spell and add it to your collection, using the same rules as that of a wizard's spellbook.

Your Deck

The card master, unfortunately, does not have his entire collection of spell cards available to him at all times. He must instead take cards from his collection and create a deck of cards from which to draw his power from in the heat of battle.

The cards in your deck determine the spells you will be able to cast that day; therefore, it must be prepared at the completion of a long rest, in much the same way a cleric, druid, or ranger would prepare their daily list of spells. However, your method of preparation is different.

Preparing your Deck

To prepare your deck, you choose a number of spell cards from your collection to add to your deck. Your deck, once complete, will have a total of twenty cards in it.

Each card represents a single casting of a spell at its base spell level. If you wish to be able to cast the same spell multiple times, or increase your likelihood of drawing it, you will need to add the card to your deck multiple times. A card master is assumed to have enough copies of the spell cards in their collection to accomodate for this requirement. You may have up to three copies of a single spell card in your deck.

Each spell card you add to your deck has a point value based on its spell level, as indicated by the Point Cost table:

Point Cost

Spell Level	First Copy	Each Additional Copy
1st	2 points	0 points
2nd	3 points	1 point
3rd	5 points	2 points
4th	6 points	3 points
5th	7 points	4 points

The total point value of the cards in your deck must not exceed the value stated in the Deck Points column of the Card Master table.

There will likely come a point where you cannot create a complete twenty-card deck using the cards in your collection. In that case, any remaining spots in the deck are filled with blank cards worth 0 points.

Your Hand

As an action, you may draw a hand of five cards from your deck. This is a representation of the powers from your deck brought to the fore, ready to be unleashed.

Cards drawn into your hand are not truly in your actual, physical hand; instead, they float intangibly about your person, circling your body but providing no real cover.

When you have used all the cards in your hand, either by casting them or discarding them, you may draw a new hand of five cards as a bonus action. Alternatively, if you do not like the hand dealt to you, you may use your action to "mulligan", shuffling your hand into your deck and drawing a new hand consisting of one fewer card than what was shuffled in.

Casting Spells

You cast spells from your hand by taking the floating card and channeling energy into it. The card itself drops to your feet, its magic spent, before transporting itself into your discard pile.

When you use a spell card to cast a spell, it is done at the lowest possible spell level. However, as part of the same action used to cast the spell, you can discard additional cards from your hand to increase the effective spell level of that spell for this casting. Each card discarded increases the spell level by one, up to your Maximum Spell Level.

You may use any card, even a blank card as described above, to cast a card master cantrip you know. When you do so, the card is shuffled into your deck, ready to be drawn again.

Your Discard Pile

Whether as a result of of casting a spell card or discarding it from your hand, expended spell cards are transported to an extradimensional space known as the discard pile. Cards in this pile are returned to your collection at the end of a long rest.

Spellcasting Ability

Charisma is your spellcasting ability for your card master spells, as card magic is fueled by sheer force of will. You use your Charisma whenever a spell refers to your spellcasting ability. In addition, you use your Charisma modifier when setting the saving throw DC for a card master spell you cast and when making an attack roll with one.

Spell save DC = 8 + your proficiency bonus + your Charisma modifier

Spell attack modifier = your proficiency bonus + your Charisma modifier

Spellcasting Focus

Your cards themselves serve as an arcane focus, replacing any material components that do not have a gold value. Your card magic is intrinsically tied to having these cards in your possession; a card master's collection must be kept complete and in good condition at all times.

A Deck with Dice?

The easiest way to play as a card master is... well... with *cards*. Using a deck of standard playing cards as a prop is the simplest way to track what is in your deck, hand, and discard pile. Simply make a note of which card represents which spell.

If such a prop is unavailable to you, it is possible to represent the randomness of a deck of cards with a single d20. Keep a list of what spells correspond to what numbers on the dice, 1-20. Whenever you would draw a card, instead roll the d20 once, and mark down which number was rolled.

When you roll the dice again, if you get a result that has already been used, simply take the next highest number.

Full House

At 1st level, as you practice your card magic, you become adept at drawing out every bit of magic you can from the cards you use. Once per day, when you finish a short rest, you can choose five cards in your discard pile and shuffle them back into your deck.

Following Suit

When you reach 2nd level, you choose a suit from the list of known suits: the Duelist, the Fortune Teller, the Gambler, and the Prestige. Your choice grants you features at 2nd level and again at 6th, 10th, and 14th level.

Cycling

At 3rd level, you have become more efficient with the way you manipulate your deck to bring forth the cards you wish to use. As a bonus action, you can discard a blank card from your hand and draw a new card to replace it.

Ability Score Improvement

When you reach 4th level, and again at 8th, 12th, 16th, and 19th level, you can increase one ability score of your choice by 2, or you can increase two ability scores of your choice by 1. As normal, you can't increase an ability score above 20 using this feature.

Awe Strike

When you reach 7th level, your powerful will makes itself known in the way you cast your spells. Whenever you cast a spell of 4th level or higher that targets one or more enemies, you can force one of them to make a Wisdom saving throw against your spell save DC. On a failed save, the creature is stunned until the end of its next turn.

Once you use this feature, you can't use it again until you complete a short or long rest.

Legendary Card

At 11th level, your card magic manifests a special, powerful spell card known as your Legendary Card. Each Legendary Card is reminiscent of its owner to some degree, and depicts how its master's magic has been influenced and shaped by their travels. This card distinguishes itself from the cards in your collection, and is not considered a part of it. Your Legendary Card vanishes from existence if you die, though it returns if you are brought back to life.

The magic held within your Legendary Card is incredibly potent. Adding it to your deck requires 25 points. However, when you draw it, its benefits are immense. As long as it is in your hand, your spell attack bonus and spell save DC get a +1 bonus, and if you attempt to discard it for any reason, it is instead shuffled into your deck.

Finally, when you first acquire your Legendary Card, choose a 6th-level spell from the card master spell list. The spell is added to your Legendary Card. Additionally, at higher levels, your Legendary Card gains more spells: one 7th-level spell at 13th level, one 8th-level spell at 15th level and one 9th-level spell at 17th level. Each of these spells may be cast from your Legendary Card once.

When you cast a spell from your Legendary Card, it returns to your deck. If you have already cast all the spells stored on your Legendary Card, it becomes the equivalent of a blank card until its magic returns at the end of your next long rest.

Deck of Legends

Starting at 20th level, when preparing your deck, you can choose to have two copies of your Legendary Card in your deck, allowing you to cast each of your 6th, 7th, 8th, and 9th-level spells twice — once from each copy. Adding the second copy of your Legendary Card to your deck costs an additional 25 points.

Following Suit

Not all card masters are created equal. Even the cards that they use themselves differ to some degree. But different specialized groups have emerged, each following a different card-based tradition. These specializations are known (in a tongue-in-cheek way) as "suits", and a card master who has chosen their path is known as "following suit" or "suited".

The Duelist

Card masters following this suit show off their magical abilities, seeking to become stronger and smarter all for the purpose of taking on other card masters. Duels between followers of this suit tend to be flashy, dramatic affairs with chains of reactive plays and sudden turns. A mild cult following has grown around Duelists, and public duels and magical tournaments are not uncommon.

One with the Cards

When you follow this suit at 2nd level, you develop a bond with your cards that extends beyond mere ownership. As an action, you may discard a card to cause it to animate, moving up to your movement speed, where it hovers in place for 1 minute before returning to your discard pile. As long as it is in the space, you can choose to perceive through it (no action required), seeing and hearing things as if you were in the space. Additionally, as a bonus action, you may choose to teleport to the card's location, ending the effect immediately.

Trump Card

At 6th level, your intuition for dueling helps you sense weakness in your opponent. As a reaction when you see an opponent make an attack or cast a spell within 20 feet of you, you may cast a spell from your hand that takes 1 action or less to cast. Once you use this feature, you can't use it again until you complete a short or long rest.

Spell Resonance

When you reach 10th level, your spells can be made more powerful with the right cards in hand. Whenever you cast a spell, if you have another copy of that spell card in your hand, you may increase the spell level for this casting by one, up to your Maximum Spell Level.

Duelist's Heart

At 14th level, your connection to your cards and your deck borders on complete union as you defy chance to draw exactly the card you need at the exact moment you need it. If your hand is empty, instead of drawing a new hand, you can use your bonus action to take a card of your choice from your deck and put it into your hand. Once you use this feature, you can't use it again until you complete a short or long rest.

The Fortune Teller

A far cry from the duelist or gambler, this type of card master prefers to keep their magic shrouded an air of mysticism. With the power of their cards, they claim to see visions of the future and influence fate. Often times, they find employ as oracles or soothsayers, operating out of tents filled with incense and smoke, waving their hands over crystal balls. Nevertheless, their powerful divination magic is not to be underestimated.

Scrying Sense

When you follow this suit at 2nd level, your powers of divination allow you to influence your deck. Whenever you draw your hand, you may instead draw six cards, returning one of your choice to your deck.

Portentous Reading

At 6th level, you may attempt to peer through the veil, catching glimpses of the future. You can take 10 minutes to perform a ritual, targeting a single willing creature, to attempt to influence fate in their favor by reading their fortune in your cards. Roll a d4. Based on the result, the DM alters fate for the targeted creature, typically by applying a bonus or penalty to random attack rolls or ability checks the target makes within the next 24 hours, using the table below:

Portent

d4 Result	Reading	Maximum Bonus/Penalty
1	Catastrophe	-5
2	Misfortune	-2
3	Small Blessing	+2
4	Triumph	+5

Other possible results of this reading include finding gold, stumbling into a trap, or getting a lucky bounce from a missed spell. Ultimately the effect is at the DM's discretion.

Once you use this feature, you can't use it again until the next dawn.

Forging Fate

At 10th level, your deck's magic shifts in focus, granting you power when you guide fate along. Whenever you cast a spell that targets one or more allies, both you and each of those allies gain temporary hit points equal to the point value of the spell card used.

Whispers from Beyond

At 14th level, your connection to your deck reaches outside of space and time. As long as you have more than ten cards in your discard pile, your ability checks are made at advantage.

The Gambler

Followers of this suit are charismatic daredevils that revel in chaos and risk, pushing the limits of their magic and themselves, calculating chance and making large sacrifices to reap large rewards. These are the card masters likely to take their places in casinos and gambling dens, either gainfully employed as entertainers, or scamming people of their hard-earned coin.

Up the Sleeve

When you follow this suit at 2nd level, after drawing a hand, you may choose one of the cards in it and make a Sleight of Hand check. The DC of this check is equal to 12 + the point value of the card you choose. If you succeed, the card disappears, and you draw a new one to replace it. At any time before you draw a new hand, you may cast this spell card. If you do, you may ignore its verbal and somatic components for this casting only.

Once you use this feature, you can't use it again until you complete a short or long rest.

Know When to Fold

At 6th level, when you are the target of an attack that you can see, or if you are subjected to an effect that allows you to make a Dexterity saving throw to take only half damage, you may discard a card from your hand as a reaction to try to escape.

If you use this feature against an attack, you only take half damage from the triggering attack. If you use it against a damaging effect, you instead take no damage if you succeed on the saving throw, and only half damage if you fail.

Tip the Scales

Starting at 10th level, you have a knack for introducing additional risk to a tense situation. Whenever you make an attack roll, ability check, or saving throw, you can choose to roll an additional 1d10 any time after making the roll but before the DM says whether the roll succeeds or fails. If the number rolled on the d10 is even, then you add the value to your result. If the number if odd, you instead subtract the value from your result.

All In

When you reach 14th level, you gain the ability to manipulate your own luck at the cost of your own life. You may use this feature when you make an attack roll, ability check, or saving throw. When you do, choose any number between 1 and 20 and use that number in place of the die roll. After the result of the roll is resolved, you then take psychic damage equal to the result (including any modifiers). This psychic damage cannot be reduced.

If you choose to roll a 20 using this feature, it does not count as a critical success.

Once you use this feature, you can't use it again until you complete a short or long rest.

The Prestige

Following this suit means adopting a different sort of mentality with your card magic. Rather than leading the high life, your stick to the shadows and back alleys, using your card magic to give you an edge over others. Through illusion and misdirection, you present yourself as a run of the mill rogue, only tipping your hand when absolutely necessary.

Hidden Hand

When you follow this suit at 2nd level, you can suppress the most ostentatious part of your ability - the floating, spectral cards that make up your hand. When you draw your hand, or as a bonus action on your turn when your hand is already drawn, you can make your cards visible to the naked eye or invisible.

Boomerang Card

Additionally at 2nd level when you follow this suit, you have improved your finesse when handling your cards. When you cast the *card throw* cantrip, if you miss a creature with one of your cards, you can cause it to curve, targeting a different creature within 10 feet of the original target. Make an additional attack roll for the new target.

You can use this ability once each time you cast *card throw*.

No Flash...

When you reach 6th level, you are able to subtly cast your spells, allowing you to go even further undetected. On your turn, when you cast a spell card, you may discard one or two cards from your hand. For each card discarded, choose one of the following options:

- You may ignore somatic components of the spell.
- You may ignore verbal components of the spell.

Additionally, when a card master spell you cast would deal damage to a target, you can use your reaction to discard spell cards from your hand. If you do, the spell deals an additional 1d6 force damage for each card discarded this way.

Trick Card

At 10th level, your knack for subterfuge improves, giving you new ways to cast your spells. As an action, you can cause one of the cards in your hand to lay flat against the floor or a solid surface. When placed this way, the card is slightly obscured, requiring an Investigation check against your spell save DC to see.

When a creature other than you moves within 5 feet of the space the card was placed in, the spell card releases a burst of magic. If the spell card you placed was an Illusion spell, it triggers the spell as if you cast it centered on that point before returning to your hand, ready to be cast again.

If the spell card you placed is not an Illusion spell, it detonates with a burst of light and sound before being discarded from your hand. Choose an effect below; the triggering creature must make a saving throw against your spell save DC based on the choice made. On a failed save, the creature suffers the resulting condition until the end of its next turn.

Trick Card Effects

Effect	Save	Result
Crack	Constitution	Deafened
Flash	Dexterity	Blinded
Shock	Wisdom	Stunned

...All Substance

When you reach 14th level, your control over your own power defies what is physically possible. On your turn, when discarding spell cards as part of your No Flash... feature, you may discard up to four cards from your hand, and you have two more options to choose from:

- The spell effect makes no noise.
- The spell effect is invisible.

Additionally, the damage dealt by discarding additional cards as part of the No Flash... feature improves to 1d8 per card discarded.

The Card Master's Conundrum

It may be overwhelming for a card master to have to build their deck after each long rest. Selecting the exact number of each spell you want to have ready for the day is not a simple task, especially with others at the table waiting.

With this in mind, it would be a good idea to have one or more deck lists prepared beforehand, adjusting them as your collection of spell cards grows larger. Making adjustments to a deck list as needed is far simpler than constructing one from whole cloth.